

STAGE ELEVEN • TOOLS & TECHNOLOGY

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Eleven • Tools & Technology

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Eleven's biggest emotional risk isn't vulnerability, as in some other stages, but embarrassment — participants may feel genuinely behind on tools they think everyone else already knows. Part 3 and Part 4 both lean on normalizing that gap explicitly, since a participant who feels embarrassed tends to disengage rather than genuinely learn.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck or intimidated.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome to Stage Eleven. This is the most hands-on stage in the program so far — you'll spend most of today with a real tool open on a real device, not just reflecting on paper.”

“A quick honesty check before we start: if you're worried you're ‘behind’ on tools compared to others in this room, you're not alone, and that's exactly why this stage exists. Everyone here has genuine gaps, including in tools they use daily.”

Opening Session 2

“Last time was about tools you probably already touch daily — Office, spreadsheets, presentations. Today goes both more foundational (your calendar, your files) and more technical (Git, AI, databases).”

“Some of today's material, especially Git, can feel intimidating if you've never touched it. That's completely normal. We're aiming for basic literacy, not expertise, in one sitting.”

Opening Session 3 (Stage Close)

“Our final session moves from individual tools to how they work together — automation, integration, and eventually stepping back to see your whole stack as one coherent system.”

“We'll close today by auditing your full tool stack, not just today's tools. Keep everything from Sessions 1 and 2 in mind as we go.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST O2 → O3

"You've committed to one productivity tool. Now let's make sure the tools you're already required to use — starting with Microsoft Office — are ones you're genuinely fluent in, not just familiar with."

FIRST O3 → O4

"We just worked on Office. Google Workspace isn't a lesser version of the same thing — it has real, different strengths worth understanding on their own terms."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Today was about tools you already touch constantly. Next session goes both more foundational, the systems underneath your daily work, and more technical — Git, AI, and databases."

FIRST O15 → O16

"You just found version history in a tool you already use. Git is the same underlying idea, just the specific tool most technical teams actually use — let's get real hands-on exposure to it."

FIRST O17 → O18

"You've now used an AI tool for one real task. The real value shows up when that becomes a consistent habit, not a one-off experiment — let's build that habit."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You've built real foundations and touched some genuinely technical territory. This final session is about connecting everything — automating, integrating, and eventually stepping back to see it all as one system."

FIRST O22 → O23

"You've identified a real repetitive task worth automating. Now let's actually build it — identification alone doesn't save any time."

FIRST O25 → O26

"You've genuinely compared two real alternatives. Comparison without a decision doesn't create any value — let's commit to one and actually implement it."

FIRST O29 → O30

"You've just mapped your full stack as a coherent whole. Now let's be honest about which pieces of that whole are actually still earning their place."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

Someone feels embarrassed they don't know a “basic” feature others seem to know

“Everyone in this room has a gap somewhere — the specific gaps just vary. The fact that you're closing one today puts you ahead of where you were yesterday, which is the only real comparison that matters.”

A participant is intimidated by Git's command-line interface (O16)

“The interface looks intimidating mostly because it's unfamiliar, not because it's genuinely hard. We're doing one basic action today, not becoming an expert — let's just get through that one action together.”

Someone is skeptical or dismissive of AI tools (O17–O18)

“That skepticism is worth naming, not dismissing. Let's try one small, real task today and see what you actually think afterward, rather than deciding based on what you've heard secondhand.”

A participant's automation attempt (O23) doesn't work on the first try

“That's genuinely normal — first automation attempts rarely work perfectly the first time. Let's look at exactly where it broke rather than treating this as a failure of the whole idea.”

Someone resists dropping a tool during the efficiency audit (O30), citing sunk cost

“The time you've already invested in a tool doesn't obligate you to keep using it if it's genuinely not earning its place anymore. What would you actually lose by switching, versus what you're currently losing by staying?”

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS (some full arcs) where participants commonly get stuck, intimidated, or resistant — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST O16

Git & GitHub Exposure

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is often the single most intimidating FIRST in the stage for non-technical participants. Keep the scope explicitly narrow (one basic action) and pair less experienced participants with more experienced ones where possible (see the Pair Programming Lite adaptation in the Group Versions document).

FIRST O17-O18

AI Tool Exploration & Workflow (full arc)

FACILITATOR NOTE

Participants often arrive with strong pre-formed opinions about AI, either overly dependent or dismissively skeptical. Both extremes are worth gently challenging with genuine, hands-on experience rather than debating the topic abstractly.

FIRST O23

Workflow Automation

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is the most technically ambitious FIRST in the stage, and a real attempt may genuinely fail or partially fail within the session. Normalize this explicitly — a failed first attempt with a clear diagnosis is a more valuable outcome than an overly simple automation that trivially succeeds.

FIRST O30

Tool Efficiency Audit

FACILITATOR NOTE

Sunk-cost attachment to a familiar tool is a genuine psychological pattern, not just stubbornness. Approach resistance to dropping a tool with curiosity about what's actually driving the attachment, rather than simply pushing participants to change.